3.2 Native Americans Unite

Thomas Jefferson kept the United States out of war. But in the years shortly after he left office, the threat of war continued to grow. Conflict was in the air, and not only in Europe.

MAIN IDEA Native Americans across North America united to fight against the American government and its increasing expansion into their traditional lands.

TECUMSEH'S IDEA

While the United States was trying to maintain neutrality in the war in Europe, trouble was developing at home. American expansion into the Northwest Territory had increased conflict with Native American nations. Shawnee chief **Tecumseh** (tuh-KUM-suh), in particular, began to speak out against the destruction of native cultures and economies. He also criticized Native American leaders who sold their land to the United States.

A Gift from the British

This ceremonial tomahawk and pipe was a gift to Tecumseh from British colonel Henry Proctor. The two men fought together on the frontier and in Canada, but they fell out over Proctor's reluctance to attack American troops in Ohio. Proctor hoped to win back Tecumseh's respect and friendship by offering him this weapon, which was most likely made in France.

To present a united front against the United States, Tecumseh visited Native American tribes, including the Miami, the Delaware, and the Potawatomi, and spoke to them about forming a confederation, or alliance. In 1809, while Tecumseh traveled the country, the U.S. government negotiated the Treaty of Fort Wayne with several other tribes. According to the terms of the treaty, the Native American leaders who signed the agreement sold 2.9 million acres of their land to the government for a fraction of a penny per acre. This type of "deal" was just what Tecumseh had been trying to prevent. The treaty was the last straw and inspired many more Native American groups to join Tecumseh's cause.

Pipe tomahawk, c. 1810–1812

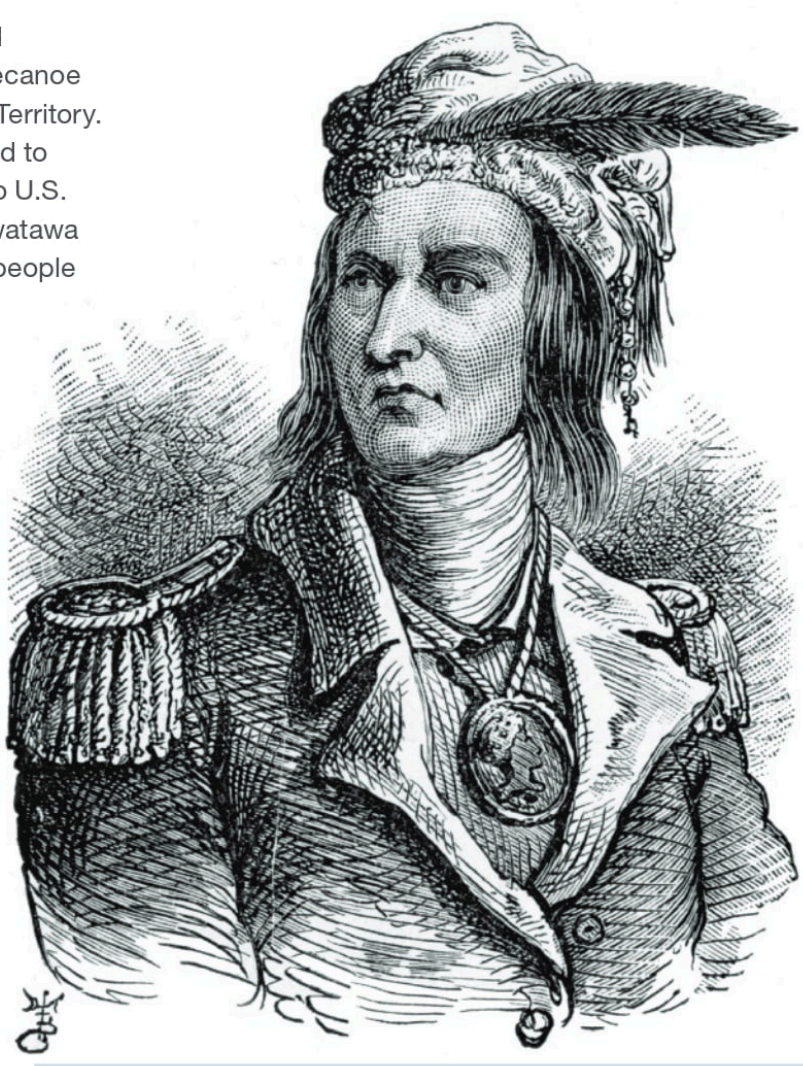
Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.

THE BATTLE OF TIPPECANOE

Meanwhile around 1808, Tecumseh had established **Prophetstown** on the Tippecanoe (tih-pee-kuh-NOO) River in the Indiana Territory. Prophetstown was a community devoted to Native American unity and opposition to U.S. expansion. Tecumseh's brother, Tenskwatawa (tens-qwah-TAH-wah), lived there, and people called him "the Prophet." A **prophet** is someone who is believed to deliver messages that come from God or some other divine source. Tecumseh's brother had become a religious leader in Prophetstown, and many of its inhabitants looked to him to foretell the future. The Prophet promoted a return to traditional ways of life and insisted that Native Americans reject all aspects of European culture.

In 1811, the governor of the Indiana Territory, William Henry Harrison, led about 1,000 men to attack the community and put an end to Tecumseh's confederacy. Tecumseh was away, trying to recruit Native Americans in the South to his cause. Acting against his brother's orders, the Prophet led an attack of his own on Harrison's camp early one morning but was soon forced to retreat. The next day, Harrison's forces found Prophetstown deserted and burned it to the ground. The skirmish came to be known as the **Battle of Tippecanoe**.

The battle infuriated many Americans. Rumors swirled that British forces in Canada had encouraged Tecumseh's confederacy and attacks by Native Americans. Some Americans who favored war, called **War Hawks**, even believed that the British had already formed an alliance with Native Americans against the United States. Many leaders felt, too, that the new nation had to demonstrate its viability, or skill, on the international stage. The War Hawks' anger boiled over in the Capitol, resulting in a call to arms. The shadow of war was falling on the country.



Tecumseh's Eloquence

Tecumseh traveled throughout the United States and Canada, persuading other tribes to join his confederacy. In one speech, he told the Osage that they "belong to one family" and were all "children of the Great Spirit." His goal of confederation, he explained, was "to assist each other to bear our burdens." Tecumseh insisted, "We walk in the same path. . . . We must be united; we must smoke the same pipe; we must fight each others' battles."

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What was Tecumseh's plan, and how did he hope to accomplish it?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What main factors led Tecumseh to formulate his plan?
3. **EVALUATE** In what ways was Tecumseh's plan a good one, and in what ways was it likely to fail?

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.